EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Is the Same Sin Worse for Some People?

Given Monday 24 February 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 5:7-8

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 5 (Merits and Demerits), the second half of Chapter 7 and Chapter 8, completing the essay

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 24 February 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: The Fifth Essay So Far

Tonight the class finishes the fifth essay, on mitzvot and aveirot, teshuvah and the status of a person. Next week, at 6 o'clock, it begins **Essay 6, on the soul**: "a difficult essay, very abstract... some concepts are quite obscure." There are ten essays, "so we are well over halfway, because the first two are the big ones."

What the essay has covered:

- **Mitzvot and aveirot leave an impression on the soul.**
- **Ten categories of people:**

#	Category	
1	Tzaddik	Majority mitzvot
2	Rasha	Majority aveirot
3	Oved	Committed to one mitzvah
4	Mamre	Disobedient to one specific mitzvah
5	Shalem	Complete; keeps all the mitzvot
6	Mekatzer	Negligent with positive commandments
7	Choteh	Offends against negative commandments
8	Mezid	Rebellious with negative commandments that carry the death penalty
9	Kofer	Serves *avodah zarah*, believes in nothing, or has significant doubts
10	Shav	The penitent

- **Theodicy:** why the righteous suffer and why the wicked prosper.
- **Teshuvah:** Saadia was the first to list its ingredients: stopping the sin now, regret, acceptance for the future and confession. Writing poetry about not sinning helps; so do prayer and charity.
- **Chapter 6**, a number of side points: **seven things that prevent prayer from being accepted**; things that **block teshuvah**, such as still having the stolen item in your hand, or causing the public to sin; **four sins for which a consequence must come in this world even after full teshuvah**, "Saadia's *chiddush*... something the later authorities didn't really take on"; and **five levels of teshuvah** (the Rambam lists three):
- repenting in exactly the same circumstances in which you sinned, and holding back;
- repenting when the circumstances are not the same;
- repenting when threatened;
- repenting once punishment has begun;
- repenting before death. That is why, Saadia writes, it is customary before death to say, **let my death be an atonement for all my sins**.
- **The first half of Chapter 7: the *beinoni*,** the eleventh kind of person. Two readings of Saadia: literally fifty-fifty, which would be very rare, or more generally someone whose identity is fifty-fifty. Either way, Hashem **מטה כלפי חסד**, tilts toward kindness, and counts him among the tzaddikim.

Chapter 7, Part 2: The Same Deed Weighs Differently

Saadia now lists contrasts: the same mitzvah is greater when one kind of person does it, and the same sin is worse when another kind of person does it. "It's the same sin two people do, but when one kind of person does something, it's worse."

Saadia does not say why he lists them here, but the Rabbi suggested it follows from something the Rambam also writes: mitzvot and aveirot are not only about the action but about **its context**, and **no one can assess the value of each mitzvah and aveirah except HaKadosh Baruch Hu**, as Yeshayahu says, "My thoughts are not your thoughts." There are countless variables; these are some of the main ones to take into account in "the great weighing."

1. The righteous person

Service from a righteous person is considered **greater**, and a sin from a righteous person is **worse**: "even the prophet and even the priest" are condemned for their hypocrisy. Probably because an important, righteous person **sets an example**. The corollary: when a well-known, righteous person sins, it is "a terrible way to cause other people to sin."

2. The holy place

Serving Hashem in a holy place is greater: "there, in My house, they will serve Me." A sin there is worse: "even in My house I found their wickedness."

This is why the Torah says in various places that a sin committed **in Eretz Yisrael** is worse than one committed outside: "the land will spit you out." "It's a great responsibility to live in Israel." And within Israel, Yerushalayim; within Yerushalayim, the Beit HaMikdash. The greater the sanctity, the greater the service and the greater the responsibility.

3. Youth and old age

Dedicating oneself to Hashem **when young** is greater than when old: **ומבחוריכם לנזרים**, "I raised up your young men as Nazirites." A sin of promiscuity by **an elderly person** is worse: in Hoshea's rebuke of Ephraim, even the old have joined in. "It's one thing, young people, full of desire, full of passion, are sinning. It's another thing when you're an old person committing these sins."

4. Wealth and honesty

Integrity from **a poor person** is more valued: **טוב רש הולך בתמו**, "better a poor man who walks in his integrity." Dishonesty from **a wealthy person** is worse. Saadia is obviously referring to **Natan's parable** to David: the man with many sheep who took the poor man's one lamb. David had many wives, and Uriyah had one; David took Batsheva and caused her to be widowed so that he could marry her.

"So the wealthier you are, whether financially wealthy or wealthy in the sense that you've got plenty of something, the more you have to be careful about your honesty." And a poor person who is scrupulous in business is on a higher level than an ordinary honest person.

5. Enemies and friends

Helping **someone you dislike** is greater; harming **a friend** is worse: "he stretched out his hands against those at peace with him."

There is an explicit Gemara on this, though "Saadia prefers to quote things from the pesukim rather than from the Chachamim," a reflection of his time, a couple of centuries after the close of the Talmud, before it carried the binding authority it had for the later Rishonim. In **the previous week's parashah**, the Torah speaks of returning the straying animal **of your enemy**. The Chachamim say: if two people need help and you can give precedence only to one, "you're driving your car and you see two people stranded," one a good friend and one someone you do not like at all, **help the one you like less**. It takes greater effort, and "that's building the relationship."

This is not about an enemy coming to kill you. There the Gemara warns against showing mercy: "you have to use your common sense with these things."

6. Humility and arrogance

Humility from **a great person** is greater: **והאיש משה ענו מאד**. Arrogance from **a lowly person** is worse.

The Rabbi noted that two lines were missing from the text on screen and supplied Saadia's proof: **כרם זלת לבני אדם** (Tehillim 12:9), the last verse of the psalm said on Shemini Atzeret. The **Radak** reads it: when the wicked are elevated, people come to cheapen the mitzvot, because they see the wicked raised up. Saadia plays on the words: when **the lowly** (*zulut*, the cheap and base) **raise themselves up** (*rum*), it is terrible. "It's one thing to be arrogant when you've got a right to be arrogant. But it's worse to be arrogant when you have no right."

7. Victims who are poor or who benefit others

Stealing from or cheating **a poor person** is worse than cheating an ordinary person: **גזלת העני בבתיכם**, "the spoil of the poor is in your houses." So too, harming **someone who benefits the public**, a righteous person with influence on others, is worse than harming an ordinary person.

8. Many acts versus one

Many acts of deceit are worse than one great deception. "A person who steals once a thousand pounds is not as bad as a person who steals twice five hundred pounds," though the total is the same.

The Rabbi asked where we learnt a similar idea, "perhaps the opposite." **The Rambam on Pirkei Avot**: better to give one coin to a thousand people than a thousand coins to one, **because every act of giving instils itself in our character**. So too every act of theft and deceit instils itself in our character.

9. Holy days

Sinning on **a special day, such as a fast day**, is worse: **הן ביום צמכם תמצאו חפץ**, "on the day of your fast you pursue your business."

"This is probably the closest you have" to explaining a puzzling practice. Many people are more careful about Yom Kippur than about Shabbat, "which really, if you think about it, doesn't make any sense at all." Driving on Shabbat carries *sekilah*, a death penalty; on Yom Kippur it carries *karet*, severe but less so. "And yet you have this practice of people that they will drive to synagogue every Shabbat, but on Yom Kippur they'll take the long walk." The only explanation is this idea: on the designated day of forgiveness and atonement, sinning is like throwing it in His face.

The Pele Yoetz. The Rabbi recalled seeing, many years ago, that the Pele Yoetz writes that a sin on **Pesach** is worse than at any other time of year. **Chametz** is puffed up, the essence of sin, which makes something look much bigger than it is; afterwards you see it was not worth it. **Matzah** is the mitzvah. This ties back to the Gemara in **Sukkah**: at the end of days the righteous and the wicked will see the *yetzer hara*. The righteous will weep: how did we conquer such a mountain? The wicked will weep: how did we fail to conquer a hair? Which is it? "Depends from which perspective." Before you sin, it looks like a mountain. Once you have done it, "it's nothing, it's not worth it, it's a hair's breadth."

10. Charity from the poor

Charity from **a poor person** is greater: **טוב מעט ביראת ה'**, "better a little with the fear of Hashem." Of course a wealthy person's charity is never diminished; "this is one variable."

11. Abstinence from the indulged

The more indulged a person is, the greater his abstinence. A fast is great, but a fast from an indulgent person is greater. In **Yoel** (the haftarah): **תקעו שופר בציון, קדשו צום... יצא חתן מחדרו וכלה מחפתה**, "blow the shofar, sanctify a fast... let the groom come out of his chamber and the bride from her canopy." Even a bride and groom at the peak of their joy should fast, and their fast is worth more than an ordinary person's.

In the same way, we are commanded to give the **first fruits**, to redeem the **firstborn son**, to bring the **firstborn animals** to the altar, and to **pray early in the morning**, because these are the most valuable to us. "You always give your best," as the Rambam also says. "My most energy, I can go for a jog, do exercise... use that time for HaKadosh Baruch Hu. That is great."

Summary of the contrasts

#	Greater merit	Greater sin
1	Service by the righteous	Sin by the righteous
2	Service in a holy place	Sin in a holy place
3	Dedication in youth	Sin in old age
4	Integrity of the poor	Dishonesty of the rich
5	Helping an enemy	Harming a friend
6	Humility of the great	Arrogance of the lowly
7		Robbing the poor; harming a public benefactor
8		Many acts of deceit rather than one
9		Sinning on a holy day
10	Charity from the poor	
11	Abstinence by the indulged	

"These are all defaults, and of course there'll be many other points to bear in mind," all going into "the great assessment HaKadosh Baruch Hu will do at the end of days."

Questions from the class

Donald asked about contrast 4: Saadia's verse ends **מעקש דרכים והוא עשיר**, "than one who is perverse in his ways, though he be rich." Shouldn't a rich person's integrity count for more, since he has more opportunities to deceive? The Rabbi thought Saadia quotes the verse only for its first half. Another participant argued that integrity and dishonesty go hand in hand: the bigger the business, the greater the scope for deceit, so a rich man's fraud is worse and his honesty correspondingly significant. They agreed it is "basically the same thing" split in two.

What counts as rich? In this context, financially wealthy: relative to others, someone with more than he needs to live, even to fund a comfortable lifestyle. It is a spectrum, and the more one has, the greater the sin of deception. (Generally, the Rabbi added, a "wealthy" person is one who is content. "I see a lot of people with money and they feel they're poor and they want more money. Unfortunately that's an illness.")

Chapter 8: Closing Reflections

"Chapter 8 is a bit of, I don't want to call it a random chapter. It's just different points all put together." About ten or eleven final reflections.

1. Thoughts

- **Good thoughts are rewarded**, even if the good is never carried out: **יעזב רשע דרכו ואיש און מחשבתיו**. The verse stresses *thoughts*; a person's hopes and intentions to do good are valuable.
- **Bad thoughts that are not acted on are not counted as deeds**, though they are **תועבת ה' מחשבות רע**, "an abomination to Hashem."
- **Except thoughts of heresy**, "because heresy is intrinsically something you do in your mind": **למען תפש את בית ישראל בלבם**, "to catch the house of Israel in their hearts."

Saadia does not quote it, but there is an explicit Gemara (**Kiddushin 39b-40a**). A father tells his son to climb up and send away the mother bird, two mitzvot whose reward in the Torah is long life, and the son falls and dies on the way. Perhaps he had a bad thought on the way up? No: **מחשבה רעה אין הקב"ה מצרפה למעשה**, Hashem does not join a bad thought to an action, except for *avodah zarah*. (A participant supplied the other half: **מחשבה טובה הקב"ה מצרפה למעשה**, a good thought Hashem does join to the deed.)

The Rabbi drew out two things:

1. The Gemara speaks of *avodah zarah*. **Saadia extends it to all heresy**, since it is all done in the mind.
2. Saadia says there **is** some guilt for bad thoughts. Someone who hates a person and fantasises about killing him, even schemes how to do it, but never has the nerve, is not punished as a murderer. Yet there is guilt in the thought itself. "It's a *chiddush*." The general understanding of the Gemara is that, though it is not good to cultivate such thoughts, there is no culpability. And on Saadia's view the Gemara's answer is puzzling: if a bad thought carries some guilt, why could it not explain the son's death? Saadia must hold that the guilt is "nowhere near as bad as an action," too little to cause such a punishment.

2. Allegorising the Torah

Allegorising a verse is legitimate, and rewarded, for **four reasons** only:

1. to reconcile it with what **our senses** perceive;
2. to reconcile it with **reason**;
3. because otherwise it would **contradict another verse**;
4. because otherwise it would contradict **our tradition**.

> if you seek it like silver and search for it like hidden treasure,"" **אם תבקשנה ככסף וכמטמונים תחפשנה**, you will find the right interpretation. Allegorising for any other reason is a sin: the Mishnah's **המגלה פנים בתורה שלא כהלכה**.

Saadia will treat this fully in **Essay 7**. The Rabbi recalled a shiur a few years ago comparing Saadia and the Rambam: the Rambam allows allegory more broadly. "There are people who call themselves Orthodox rabbis who have allegorised the Avot, Avraham, Yitzchak and Yaakov... that's wrong."

Doron asked whether the Rambam allegorises Gan Eden and the snake. The Rabbi did not remember either way and would check, but noted that a talking snake conflicts with our senses, so even Saadia might accept it. The Rambam certainly reads **Bilam's donkey** non-literally: "he understands there's no such thing as the donkey of Bilam speaking." Where is the line? "It's very hard," since one can always claim something conflicts with reason; the Rabbi's understanding is that for the Rambam one may not allegorise against a fundamental of faith, so one could not allegorise away the splitting of the Yam Suf.

3. Allegorising the mitzvot

Someone who allegorises **mitzvot** and leads people to doubt whether to perform them behaves like **the false prophets**, "who follow their own spirit." "You can allegorise verses in the Torah. You can't allegorise mitzvot."

"This is interesting, and I'll tell you why." This was very widespread, "believe it or not," in Andalusia and beyond in the eleventh to thirteenth centuries. The Rambam had minor controversies in his lifetime, but the two major ones came after his death in 1204:

- **in the 1230s**, involving **Rabbeinu Yonah**, when the Rambam's books were burnt (Rabbeinu Yonah later admitted it was wrong);
- **in the 1290s**, with **the Rashba** and **Abba Mari**.

In both, opponents claimed that because of the Rambam people were allegorising mitzvot. The letters show that some scholars said **tefillin** were not literal boxes to wear but contents to contemplate, "wear the boxes in your mind," and the same for many other mitzvot.

4. New ideas about God and creation

Those who invent new ideas about God are doing something terrible. Some explained **נעשה אדם בצלמנו**, "let us make man in our image," as Hashem creating man together with an angel, to make it greater; but **נשאו לשוא עריך**, they exalt You in vain, because it detracts from the unity of God. "Be careful when you're explaining things about HaKadosh Baruch Hu and about creation, that you are honest and stick to the tradition."

5. The judge who punishes

A judge who imposes punishment **to protect the Torah**, as the Chachamim allow in order to make a fence, is rewarded. A judge who does it **for his own benefit**, for a sense of superiority, does terrible harm to his own soul.

Why does Saadia include this? Some say he is referring to **David ben Zakkai**, the Exilarch, with whom he clashed many times, as the class learnt in its very first shiur on Saadia over a year ago. Saadia lost his position over a financial case that the Exilarch insisted be decided one way, because Saadia stood up for the truth.

6 to 10. No excuse

Saadia lists situations that are **no excuse**:

6. The ignorant	Those who go and ask the Chacham are praised. But if you never bothered to ask, "you can't say, I didn't know," because you had the chance to learn. "If you tried to learn and made mistakes, that's fine."
7. The poor and prayer	If you could not pray because you were working every moment to put bread on the table, you have an excuse. "But if you had a spare five minutes and you didn't use those five minutes for prayer," that will be held against you. Poverty excuses only what poverty requires
8. The sick	Terrible illness or tragedy is no excuse for cursing Hashem and saying He is unfair: **ולא זעקו אלי בלבם כי יייליו על משכבותם**, "they did not cry out to Me with their heart, but wail upon their beds"
9. The drunk	Drunkenness is no excuse; you bear full liability, "something reflected nowadays in civil law as well." Saadia quotes the Gemara in **Eruvin**, though not the full story: at **the drunkenness of Lot**, a far extreme, transactions are void and some liabilities do not apply
10. The oppressed	Jews oppressed by non-Jews have no excuse to abandon Torah and mitzvot. "As Jews, most of us have done this most of the generations," though there have always been some who went over to the other side

11. Teshuvah once more

- **Repeating a sin** makes it harder: **ככלב שב על קאו**, "like a dog returning to its vomit." Saying "I will sin and then do teshuvah" does not work. This is not a contradiction of Chapter 5, where relapse after a genuine teshuvah did not undo it; here he means someone who repents while intending to sin again.
- **Yom Kippur alone does not work.** "You may have thought Yom Kippur works for everyone. No. Yom Kippur only works together with teshuvah."
- **Causing others to sin** makes teshuvah very hard. But one who **causes others to do good** will not easily be punished: because he guarded My ways, I will guard him.

"I could bring many examples, I'd never end. These are the main principles." So Saadia concludes the fifth essay.

Summary

1. **Chapter 7:** the same deed weighs differently depending on **who** does it, **where**, **when**, **to whom** and **how often**: eleven contrasts, all part of a weighing only Hashem can make.
2. **Thoughts:** good intentions are rewarded; bad ones are not counted as deeds, but for Saadia carry **some** guilt; heresy, in the mind, is judged as a deed.
3. **Allegory:** permitted only to reconcile Scripture with the senses, reason, other verses or tradition. **Never allegorise mitzvot**, a live issue in the Rambam controversies.
4. **Stick to tradition** in speaking of God and creation; a judge must punish for the Torah's sake, not his own (perhaps aimed at David ben Zakkai).
5. **No excuse** for ignorance one could have remedied, prayer one had time for, cursing in illness, drunkenness, or abandoning Judaism under oppression.
6. **Teshuvah:** repeated sin is harder to undo; Yom Kippur needs teshuvah; causing others to sin, or to do good, has lasting weight.

Coming Up

Next week, be'ezrat Hashem: **Essay 6, the *nefesh*, the soul.**

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